

STAGING THE UNSTAGEABLE:
Performing the Crucifixion in
Late Medieval and Early Modern England

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Through all his work on the editing of the Chester Plays and the county's documentary records, his studies of the urban background to the Plays' presentation, their theology, and their literary qualities, David Mills has always had a foot in the theatre as well. I have fond memories of being shanghaied at the last moment for the Chester *Balaam and Balaak* pageant in 1983 with virtually no rehearsal, and being given such concise and clear direction by David that rehearsal seemed unnecessary. To honour David's involvement in and his support for performance, I want to investigate the staging of the Crucifixion in early British drama — not its theological centrality to the Christian religion, but explicitly its staging and the problems presented in the public recreation of a horrific act of torture and murder. What difficulties faced those involved in mounting such a play and how were they faced? What decisions had to be made, and what can the play-texts as well as the records of performance tell us about the ways in which these problems were solved? Although the scholarly literature on most of the plays is extensive, no discussion of the *Crucifixion* pageants has looked at them broadly and comparatively, and rarely from the aspect of stage technique.

Official reaction to the dramatic representation of the Crucifixion has hardly been stable over the years. In the period of time of which some of us at least have memory, that is until the early 1950s, it was thought to be illegal in the United Kingdom to represent a divine figure on stage, although surviving pictures suggest that when William Poel produced *Everyman* in 1901, the person of God who calls Everyman to account did in fact appear on stage.¹ Only with the Festival of Britain production of parts of the York Cycle in 1951 did the taboo begin to be lifted, and even then it took almost two decades. With the Crucifixion this wariness has been particularly strong. As Stanley Kahrl wrote in 1974:

[The York Crucifixion] has not normally been staged as originally intended in the triennial productions at York of the past two decades, initially because the cathedral authorities felt that it was too much for a modern audience to take, later because it was felt that it was too difficult to enact the actual raising of the cross in a properly reverent

fashion. Margaret Birkett, whose production of the N-Town Plays at Grantham in 1966 was singularly effective in realizing the theatrical power of that cycle's scourging scenes, nevertheless balked at staging the Crucifixion itself, faking it behind the same wall of banners as employed at York. Not until the production of the Cornish cycle in 1969 did I see a properly executed Crucifixion staged in the twentieth century ...²

Things have clearly changed since the 1960s, as anyone who has seen Mel Gibson's *Passion of the Christ* will know, and there is evidence that this broad range of reactions, both public and administrative, existed in the Middle Ages as well.

The biblical plays of Chester, York, N.Town, Towneley, and Coventry were, for the most part, products of the later fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, and if there is some limited evidence that biblical plays were staged in British towns in the fourteenth and earlier fifteenth centuries, we have little idea of what they may have been like. It seems quite likely that a Crucifixion play of the fourteenth century might have come up against a similar reaction from authority as it would have received from the Lord Chancellor in the twentieth. In September of 1320, Adam Orleton, the fierce and authoritarian bishop of Hereford, wrote to the monks of the Benedictine priory of Abergavenny which, though across the Welsh border in Monmouthshire, was under his jurisdiction. He complains of abuses of the monastic rule: engaging in 'indecent and shameful conversations' in the cloister and refectory, eating meat even on Wednesdays and neglecting to observe the fasts of Advent and other times, playing at dice and other games when they should be singing the divine office. These are all pretty standard complaints, and can be found in almost any bishop's register; Orleton goes on, though, to complain that:

... & quosdam ipsorum spectaculum/ suorum corporum facientes & aliquociens quod non sine cordis amaritudine referimus nudi extensis brachiis cum baculis & ligatis ad modum crucifixi stramine vel alio aliquo ad modum corone/ capitibus eorum superposito de ipsorum dormitorio nocturno tempore descendentes & sic incedentes. ac ludentes coram sociis suis/ & aliis inibi morantibus & alia enormia facientes que ad presens/ propter ipsorum enormitatem nimiam subticemus ...

... and some of them make a spectacle of their bodies and sometimes — which we did not learn without bitterness of heart — they come down naked from their dormitory at night, with arms stretched out with rods and tied in the manner of someone crucified, with straw or something

else in the manner of a crown put upon their heads, and walk in that way and play before their fellows and others staying there and do other outrageous things, about which we are silent at present because of their excessive outrageousness ...³

Orleton's outrage sadly prevents him from being more specific in detail, but the phrasing of his objections, that the monks are displaying themselves *ad modum crucifixi* ('in the manner of someone crucified'), that they are wearing headpieces *ad modum corone* ('in the manner of a crown'), and that they are *ludentes coram sociis suis* ('playing in the presence of their fellows'), strongly suggests some mimesis of the Crucifixion. I have a suspicion that the sexual overtones of the complaint, implicit principally in the monks' nakedness and the 'outrageousness' of their behaviour, are due more to Orleton's disapproval than to the irreverence of their presentation. Had Orleton said 'they mimic Christ at his Crucifixion wearing only a loincloth' we would read the passage rather differently. There is no indication whether playing before their fellow monks and guests involved a spoken text, a mimed action, or simply a *tableau vivant*. What is clear is that Orleton thought it was in the worst possible taste, much as the Lord Chancellor would have reacted to an onstage God at any time between the late-sixteenth and mid-twentieth centuries. By the time of the first English Crucifixion play which has come down to us, this situation had clearly changed as radically as it did at the end of the twentieth century, and this change can be traced directly to the changes in modes of worship which preceded it. These changes, typified by the *devotio moderna* movement in the Netherlands and Germany and the mode of 'affective piety' promulgated by such popular texts as Nicholas Love's *Mirror of the Blessed Life of Jesus Christ*, urged the devotional reader to imagine in detail the wounds of Christ or the grief of Mary, to recreate for him or herself their physical sufferings.⁴ Although we cannot follow the exact course by which the staging of the Crucifixion became an accepted part of public civic devotion, these attitudes would have provided fertile ground for a performance like that of the monks of Abergavenny.

As Kahrl noted, the reluctance of the York and Grantham directors in the 1950s and 1960s to follow the text and stage directions of the medieval *Crucifixion* pageants was the result, quite bluntly, of squeamishness; that the violence of these pageants was too much for a modern audience to bear, and that it would not be possible to raise the cross in a 'properly reverent manner'.⁵ Both the texts of the pageants and their indications of stage action make it very clear that neither the medieval producers nor the audiences of these pageants had any such qualms, and that any attempt to raise the Cross

in a reverent manner would be antithetical to the whole purpose of the pageant. Many of the Crucifixion plays are violent, but their violence is the point of the play. This violence is very much a part of the late medieval note of affective piety seen perhaps most spectacularly in the Crucifixion by Matthias Grünewald in the Isenheim Altarpiece, now in the Unterlinden Museum in Colmar, Alsace.⁶ This intense concentration and meditation on the physical details of Christ's suffering (precisely the opposite of the York-Grantham assumption that the audience would be unable to bear it) was in itself a mode of devotion, and a path leading to a higher spiritual plane, as Nicholas Love explains:

For to him þat wolde serche þe passion of oure lorde with alle his herte & alle his inwarde affeccione þere shuld come many deuout felynges & stirynges þat he veuer supposede before. Of þe which he shuld fele a newe compassion & a newe loue, & haue newe gostly confortes, þorh þe which he shold perceyue him self turnede as it were in to a newe astate of soule, in þe which astate þoo forseide gostly felynges, shold seme to him as a nerneste & partie of the blisse & ioy to come.⁷

Love makes clear that what he means by 'serche þe passion' is the attempt to participate imaginatively in the events of the Passion, to make real to one's self the physical and mental suffering of Christ and Mary. This, of course, is exactly what the Crucifixion plays do.

I want to approach each of the surviving English Crucifixion pageants and plays from the point of view of staging, in very approximate chronological order. The sequence will of necessity be rough, since in most cases the only dates we can associate with the individual plays with any certainty are the dates of the manuscripts. In many cases, as at York and Chester, there is clear evidence of a performance tradition significantly antedating the manuscripts, although we have no way of knowing whether the plays performed at those earlier periods were identical with those in the manuscript, prior versions of the same plays, or different plays altogether.

Arguably the York pageant of the *Crucifixion* is the finest representation of the event in all the English dramatisations of the Passion. It is also the most intensely focussed of the plays, eliminating everything but Christ himself and the four Soldiers. The laments of John and the three Maries are placed in the previous play, *The Road to Calvary*, while the lament of Mary at the foot of the Cross appears in the following pageant, *The Death of Christ*. We have no idea by whom or exactly when the York pageants as they survive in the unique manuscript may have been written, but the decision to excise everything from

the Crucifixion pageant except Christ himself and the four Soldiers must have been a conscious one, and must have involved some negotiation between the Pinners, the guild responsible for that pageant, and the Shearmen and the Butchers, who were responsible for the pageants before and after respectively. The result is an intensity of focus more powerful than that of any other surviving Passion play, whether English or Continental. The content of the pageant is reduced simply to the action of the Crucifixion and to the relationship between Christ and his executioners. It has often been noted that the playwright is very concerned with answering the question, 'How could four human beings treat someone in such an inhuman manner?' After the horrors of the past century, this question is perhaps less meaningful for us, but there is no question that it was very much in the mind of the anonymous playwright. His answer is simple: there is no interaction on a human level between Christ and the Soldiers. For the most part, they do not speak to Christ, and treat him merely as a part of the job they have been ordered to do. Their interest throughout the pageant is entirely focussed on their work. They complain of its difficulty, of the incompetence of the preparation of the Cross (done by others, of course), so that the holes for the nails have been bored in the wrong places (a detail present in all the English plays),⁸ of the weight of the Cross with the body of Christ on it, and of their small pay (supplemented meagrely by Christ's cloak). They discuss their tools, the details of the job, the best way to lift the Cross. They rarely acknowledge the presence of Christ: the only times are when they call him forward, when he lies down properly on the Cross (saving them the labour of putting him there), when they note the pain the nailing will cause him, and after the Cross is raised, in order to fulfil the Scriptural requirement that he be mocked. Other than this, the Soldiers speak of Jesus only in the third person, placing him on the same level as their tools, the ropes they need to bind him to the Cross, and the Cross itself. The way in which the Cross is raised and lowered into its mortise is precisely laid out in the Soldiers' lines: Christ is nailed to the Cross while it is lying on the ground. The First Soldier, clearly the foreman, directs them in raising the heavy Cross, against the objections of the lazy Fourth Soldier, who is convinced that they will not be able to raise it to the mortise:⁹

I wene it wolde neuere come þore —
We foure rayse it not right to-yere.

163–4

Rebuked by his superior, the Fourth Soldier agrees to take charge of the bottom of the Cross and to direct it into the mortise — the suggestion is there that this would be the least strenuous job. Soldiers Two and Three take the

two sides of the cross-piece, leaving the top for the First Soldier from which position he can direct the job. He gives the command to lift, and they move it part-way until the First Soldier complains that his shoulder is giving out; the Fourth Soldier orders the Cross to the ground, and they rest a moment bickering over the difficulty of the job. They try again, and this time they bring the Cross to the mortise. 'Pe werste is paste,' says the Second Soldier with relief (212). 'He weyes a wikkid weght,' complains the Third (213). The First Soldier orders the Cross lifted into the mortise, where it is dropped in, as he makes clear:

Pis fallyng was more felle
Pan all the harmes he hadde. 225-6

The most important stage property which this pageant defines is the piece of wood containing the mortise, which acts as a 'hole' into which the Cross can be dropped and stabilized. Since the York Play was processional, played at a sequence of sites about the city, the mortise into which the Cross is set must be portable, and since it must be stable with the weight of the Cross and the actor playing Christ, it must be attached firmly to the play's waggon. Although we cannot be sure of the size of the waggons, the streets of York would have given a rough maximum, perhaps just big enough to hold the Cross with the mortise at one of the ends. Since the Cross must be moved into position in two stages, this would imply that the nailing might have been done on the ground, in the area called *platea* or 'in the sreet' in many of the texts. In practice this method of raising the Cross works extremely well and is highly effective from a dramatic point of view, though it is a bit frightening for the actor playing Christ. Ropes on the cross-piece are essential for him to hang on to as the Cross falls at least three feet into its slot, depending on the height of the waggon. The mortise is made intentionally loose so that the Cross will slide into it easily, as is made clear by the Soldiers who must drive wedges in around the Cross to secure it in place. As the First Soldier says,

Goode wegges schall we take pis tyde
And feste þe foote, þanne is all fitte. 235-6

The 'gere' which the Soldiers bring with them as props, the 'hammeres and nayles large and lange' (30) which Soldier Three produces at the beginning of the pageant also have their technical uses. The nails, slotted into the Cross's pre-drilled holes and hammered in firmly, provide an essential pair of hand-holds for Christ as the Cross is lifted, wobbles, and is carried into place for

dropping into the mortise. The hammer which drove the nails is also used to pound in the wedges which stabilize the Cross.

There is one final puzzle to the play. In the final action, Soldiers Two, Three, and Four propose drawing lots for Christ's cloak, but the First Soldier — who has been in charge of the detail — takes the cloak and claims possession. Soldier Two has the final lines of the play:

Goo we panne hense tyte,
 Bis trauayle here we tyne &c. 299–300

These lines present three problems. First, Soldier Two seems to be acquiescing to Soldier One's ownership of the cloak much too easily; second, what does the last line mean; finally, what is the *etcetera* doing at the end of the play? One dramatic action which provides a possible solution to all three questions is that Soldier One grabs the cloak and runs off. Soldier Two's first line then is not acquiescence, but a direction to the other two to chase him and retrieve the cloak. I would then read the last line to mean something like, 'We're wasting our time here ...' and the final *etcetera* would indicate that he and the others improvise yelling at Soldier One as they run after him. The only other explanation I can think of is that *etcetera* may simply be an indication in the manuscript Register that (unlike the divisions between most of the plays) this one has not come to a conclusive ending and leads directly into the following play, *The Death of Christ*, and Pilate's pompous opening.

The only other English play surviving from the fifteenth century is the so-called N.Town *Passion Play*. It could not be more different from York. In their joint edition of the manuscript facsimile, Stanley Kahrl and Peter Meredith outlined the complicated nature of this manuscript, in which an assembly of discrete pageants has likely been disrupted by the insertion both of a play on the life of the Virgin Mary and a sequence of two separate plays dealing with the events of the Passion, the first leading up to Jesus' arrest, and the second running from the trial before Herod to the posthumous appearance to Mary Magdalene. The Crucifixion sequence thus falls within the second *Passion Play*, and it is both extraordinarily brief and heavily overladen with other of the events and themes, both canonical and apocryphal, which surround the Crucifixion narrative itself. The procession to Calvary packs three events into 48 lines — the lament of the two women and Jesus' reply, 'Dowterys of Hierusalem, for me wepyth nowth' (707), based on Luke 23:28; Simon of Cyrene's bearing of the Cross in Jesus' stead; and Veronica's wiping of Christ's face.¹⁰ The evidence is substantial that the original pageants of the N.Town series were intended for stationary place-and-scaffold staging rather

than processional staging as in York, and this brief series of vignettes would likely have covered the movement of the procession from the Council House scaffold, where the scourging has just taken place, to the Calvary scaffold.

Comments on the York *Crucifixion* pageant usually note its brevity, but the N.Town play packs the nailing and the raising of the Cross into 43 lines. In stark contrast to York, much of the action takes place in stage directions rather than in the speeches, and these stage directions are singularly unforthcoming about the way in which the scene is staged. The first one outlines the nailing: 'Pan xul þei pulle Jesu out of his clothis and leyn them togedyr; and þer þei xul pullyn hym down and leyn hym along on þe cros, and aftyr þat naylyn hym þeron' (sd at 746). The details are elaborated only slightly in the speeches of the soldiers which follow, picking up the mis-bored cross motif and the necessity of ropes to bring Christ's body to the pre-drilled holes. This is followed by the direction, 'Here xule þei leve of and dawncyn abowte þe cros shortly' (sd at 774); their dance accompanied by four lines of mocking. The raising of the Cross finds no description in the speeches of the soldiers: one of them says 'set up þe cros on þe hende / Pat we may loke hym in þe face' (779–80). There is none of the interest here which we saw in the York pageant in the details of raising the Cross; this direction to 'set up þe cros' is immediately followed by the stage direction, 'Here qwan þei han set hym up þei xuln gon before hym seyng eche aftter other þus' (sd at 782). Their four further lines of mocking conclude the sequence and lead directly into the crucifixion of the two thieves and the lament of Mary. Jesus does not speak between his warning to the two women on the road to Calvary, and his prayer that the soldiers be forgiven which follows Mary's lament. The structure of the scene could not be more different from that of York, and the York playwright's two primary interests — the mechanics of raising the Cross, and the attempt to understand the minds of the soldiers — are entirely lacking here in favour of a grander pageant with all the personae of the Gospel account on stage.

Also surviving in a fifteenth-century manuscript, Bodley 791, though quite likely dating from the previous century, the *Cornish Passion* is the central play of a massive three-day-long dramatization of the history of the world. Preceded by a play of the Creation and Old Testament history, and followed by a play of the Resurrection and the eschatological history of the future, the *Passion Play* (like N.Town) was clearly intended for stationary place-and-scaffold staging, in this case utilizing a large earthwork playing-place, such as still survive at several sites in Cornwall. In N.Town the details of the Crucifixion itself were reduced to a bare minimum, with most of the action of

nailing Christ to the Cross and raising it into its mortise accomplished without words. In the Cornish play, both scriptural and apocryphal sources are used to structure a far more elaborate version of the Crucifixion narrative. Significantly, a wealth of detail is given in the text, implying a very elaborate use of props. Central to this is the provision of the Cross itself. Directed by Pilate to crucify Jesus, the four Soldiers begin by discussing where to get wood to make the Cross — one of them suggests a cursed piece of wood he knows at Cedron, and they go to fetch it. The stage direction reads, *transeunt ad Cedron pro ligno crucis*.¹¹ Returning with the wood, it is clear that it is rough and not yet made into a cross, even though a stage direction 38 lines earlier seems to have directed the making of the crosses: *hic paratur lignum crucis in cedron et due cruces pro latronibus*.¹² The Fourth Soldier cuts the wood in two with his axe to make a cross-piece and an upright, and the First Soldier bores the holes. The following stage direction suggests a further complex action: *hic parantur due cruces pro latronibus*.¹³ In a play which is already extremely elaborate and eventful, it is clear that the actions suggested by the Soldiers' lines and the stage direction do not reflect the actual cutting and building of three crosses on stage. To fulfill the Fourth Soldier's cutting of the wood in two, the pieces of the Cross must have been joined or tied together in some way; the holes pre-drilled and covered or filled in some way easily removable. The strong implication that the cross-piece is not yet attached to the upright would suggest that the soldiers tie or peg them together in some manner sufficiently secure to permit the Cross to be raised and dropped into the mortise without serious injury to the actor playing Jesus. The episodes with the lamenting women and Simon's bearing of the Cross are both included, as well as a lament for the Virgin. Surprisingly, the entire Crucifixion is then interrupted as the Four Soldiers go off to a smith for nails and the whole apocryphal story of the Smith's Wife who forges the nails after her husband's refusal is dramatised. The Cornish play is the only insular version to include this scene, though it appears in continental plays such as the French *Passion Play* from Sémur, suggesting that the Cornish play's extensive differences from the English plays may place it rather closer to the continental tradition. There is also some redundancy in the action, as the soldiers announce that they will bore the holes, which they have in fact already done almost 200 lines earlier.¹⁴

Between the nailing of Christ's hands and feet he asks forgiveness for the Soldiers; the Third Soldier directs two of his companions to tie the two Thieves to their crosses while he drives the nail through Christ's feet. Pilate adds his inscription 'King of the Jews' while the Cross is still on the ground.

Little detail is given of the raising of the Cross, but there is clearly a mortise or a hole into which to drop it. The Second Soldier says, 'Raise up the cross and put it in place!'¹⁵ The stage direction reads *sublevat crucem*; this is likely a scribal error for the plural verb (a missing stroke over the *a* indicating a syncopated *n*), rather than an indication that the Second Soldier raises the Cross on his own. He continues his directions, 'Everyone lift, and let's drop it into the socket with a crack'.¹⁶ The positioning of Calvary in the permanent structure of a Cornish round is not clear; if it were one of the scaffolds a mortise would seem to be indicated, if it were the central *platea* the 'socket' the soldier refers to would be more likely to be set in a hole in the ground. The Cornish *yn mortar* could refer to either.¹⁷

Although it only survives in manuscripts dating from the mid-sixteenth century and later, the Welsh-language *Passion Play* from north-east Wales, generally ignored in discussions of the genre, is strikingly unlike its closest neighbour, the pageant from the Chester cycle. It is far more like the Cornish play and the N.Town pageant, though composed rather than broken down into a sequence of pageants. It is very much unlike those plays, though, in its brevity, compressing the events from Simon's carrying the Cross to Christ's *Videte* speech into about 150 lines, with a running time of approximately fifteen minutes. There are no stage directions, and the actual raising of the Cross indicated by four lines, as the First Knight says, 'My friends, drive the nails into his hands and feet and lift him up high that the Jews may see'.¹⁸ The play-text includes no indication of how the nailing is to proceed, whether ropes are to be used, whether the holes are bored properly, how the Cross is to be raised or whether a mortise is needed. The play gives by far the least evidence for staging of any from the period, and it is only the use of direct address to the audience that implies that it was intended for performance or dramatised reading rather than for private reading.

The Chester Whitsun Plays survive in five manuscripts from the late sixteenth century, the only plays for which we have more than one exemplar. Although the manuscripts are late, all dating from after the last performance of the cycle in 1575, the city's records give ample evidence for the mounting of the Plays through the earlier part of the century, slim though reliable evidence for their performance in some form through the fifteenth century from at least 1422, and much less reliable hints that they may have existed before that. The *Crucifixion* play, staged appropriately by the Ironmongers, has an odd rhythm to it, one whose sense only becomes clear in performance. The sequence of events from the approach to Calvary, Christ's address to the Women of Jerusalem, Simon's carrying the Cross, the nailing and raising of

the Cross, and Jesus' *Videte* speech (in this case from the Cross), proceed swiftly and inexorably in most of the plays (with the significant exception of the Cornish play's diversions to fetch wood and nails). In the Chester pageant, however, the sequence is interrupted by the Soldiers' dicing for Jesus' seamless mantle. Unlike the Cornish play, in which the diversions tend to defuse the action in a scene which appears to be comedic, the Soldiers' gaming has no such effect in Chester. Peter Travis describes the effect of this dramatic movement:

Chester's insertion of the dicing before the Crucifixion is uniquely strategic, for in momentarily distracting the audience from its heretofore uninterrupted contemplation of Christ's progress, the dicing episode briefly suspends the growing emotions of compassion and terror. Although Christ is present throughout the dicing, standing as a bloody spectacle before the audience, the shift in dramatic focus away from him to the *tortores'* myopic interest in the fall of dice makes the dramatic return to Christ's next torture all the more powerful.¹⁹

I do not entirely agree with Travis; up until his last line my reading follows his, but the purpose of the episode is not to increase the power of the return to Christ. First, although Travis is right that the dramatic focus shifts in the direction of the Soldiers and their game, Christ is clearly near them, silent, throughout the dicing. It is clear that he is standing, since 24 lines after the dicing the Second Soldier tells the others to lay Christ on the Cross. At the same time the Soldiers are likely either bending over or sitting to cast the dice. We have already seen in York the power of the silent Christ, and although the *action* of the episode is in the Soldiers' dicing, the dramatic *focus* remains on the central figure in his silence. The purpose of the episode, as well as its curious placement, is intended to indicate the primary concerns of the Soldiers, for whom the dicing and the winning of the cloak are far more exciting than the work of execution.

The mis-boring of the Cross and the use of ropes to stretch Christ's body to the pre-drilled holes is noted briefly by the Soldiers, but with none of the York workmen's comments on the effect of this torture on Christ. Chester's playwright has very little interest in the actual raising of the Cross, which appears to occur without comment from any of the Soldiers. The First Soldier notes that the deadline they have been given is approaching fast,

Yea, helpe nowe that hee
on height raysed bee,

for, as mote I thee,
almost hit ys noone.²⁰

213-6

This is followed immediately by a stage direction introducing Pilate, who has come to place his inscription, 'Jesu of Nazareth ... Kynge of Jewes', over Christ's head. How he gets his sign up on the Cross is not clear, but the short argument with the Soldiers which follows makes it clear that the Cross has already been raised. There is no mention of a mortise, nor of the Cross's weight nor the difficulty of raising it, nor of Christ's suffering in the process. After a series of laments by the four Maries and Jesus' request for forgiveness — here directed not just to the Soldiers but to Annas, Cayphas, and Pilate as well, the two crucified Thieves speak. There is no indication in the text of how or when their crosses were raised.

Although this examination of the *Crucifixion* plays of late medieval Britain has proceeded in a roughly chronological order, I have saved the pageant from the Towneley manuscript to the end, even though its manuscript clearly antedates those of the Chester Plays.²¹ With the Towneley *Crucifixion* pageant we return full circle to York for, although it is not one of the pageants borrowed from the York Play, the action of the pageant suggests to me very strongly that its author had seen York's version and had been profoundly influenced by it. The pageant begins on the road to Calvary, with the four soldiers checking their tools as they walk, a fact presented by the Third Soldier who remarks that they have reached the place. Christ's laying himself down on the Cross is here replaced by the very literary topos of *Christus miles* riding to battle on his horse, as the soldiers joke about seating Jesus on his palfrey:²²

Stand near, fellows, and let see
How we can horse our king so free
By any craft;
Stand thou yonder on yond side,
And we shall see how he can ride
And how to wield a shaft.

107-12

The soldiers' reaction to the mis-bored cross follows York, but is expanded as Soldiers Two, Three, and Four each try to pull the hand to the hole, ignoring the First Soldier's direction that it will take three to pull and one to drive the nail. After they realize that he's right, their grunts and groans, written into the text, mirror those of the York Soldiers in their attempts to raise the Cross:

2. Pull therat with som kyn gyn!
3. Yee, and bryng it to þe marke.

4. Pull, pull!
1. Haue now!
2. Let se!
3. Aha!
4. Yit a draght!
1. Therto with all my maght!
2. Aha! hold still thore!

189-93

The hard work of raising the Cross and dropping it into its mortise is reflected in the Soldiers' words, and as they begin to lift the Second Soldier complains that the assembly is unbalanced. The clear directions of York concerning what part of the job is undertaken by each Soldier are missing in Towneley, as the Cross is quickly upended and let fall into its mortise. Proud of their work, the Second Soldier notes, 'Ah, it stands up like a mast' (232). Even more silent than in York, Jesus speaks for the first time in the pageant from the Cross. The scriptural *Videte*, which was given a dozen lines in York, is here expanded to a massive 66 lines of complaint.

Jesus' long speech is followed by a curious passage which at first suggests that the Cross has not yet been raised. The four soldiers talk about dropping the Cross into the mortise as if they had not yet done that:

1. Lif us this tree amongs us all.
2. Yea, and let it into the mortice fall,
And that shall gar him brest.
3. Yea, and all to-rive him, limb from limb.
4. And it will break ilk joint in him
Let see now who does best!

305-10

Where the York workmen at this point were principally concerned about stabilizing the Cross, driving in wedges to hold it securely in the mortise, Towneley's Soldiers are playing a sadistic game in which they lift the Cross up in its socket and let it fall again. The York playwright was intensely concerned with reconciling in some way the Soldiers' actions with their necessary humanity; the Towneley playwright has no such concern — his Soldiers are brutes and cannot even fall back on the 'just following orders' defence. Although the first part of the Towneley pageant, up to the raising of the Cross, has much of the terseness of York, the second half falls apart in long speeches. Jesus' long complaint and the bouncing of the Cross in its mortise are followed by almost two hundred lines of lament by Mary and John, and Jesus' reply of thirty-odd lines. The four Soldiers must remain during the twenty minutes or so these laments would take, since the scene

which follows includes their mocking of the crucified Christ, their dicing over the mantle, and their complaint to Pilate over his inscription. What are they doing during the laments? This is not like the Chester pageant in which a divided focus has clear dramatic importance; virtually anything the Towneley Soldiers do is likely to upstage the static laments.

The laments themselves derive from scriptural sources but — more importantly — they are filtered through the devotional lyric poetry of the fifteenth and early sixteenth century, frequently through the intermediary of liturgical practice. In the light of this, as well as the playwright's use of the highly literary image of Christ 'riding' the Cross like a horse which I mentioned earlier, I would suggest that the author of the Towneley pageant was a well-trained poet who had relatively little experience writing for a dramatic purpose. He had, I think, seen the York *Crucifixion* pageant and was mightily impressed, but for him the desire to write a lengthy series of verse laments appropriate to the highly charged atmosphere of the *Crucifixion* outweighed his understanding of dramatic rhythm and tension.

I began this survey of the surviving *Crucifixion* plays from late medieval and Tudor Britain with the specific intention of seeing what they could tell us of their stage technology. Although the raising of the Cross is not exactly a 'special effect' in the present sense of the phrase, it clearly represented a technical difficulty which had to be solved in each series of plays which covered the events of Christ's death. While a play like the Welsh *Passion* contains so little detail indicating staging that it might well have been part of some kind of sequence of *tableaux vivants*, most of these plays require that Christ be attached to the Cross in such a way that the whole thing can be raised and dropped into a mortise without injury either to the actor playing Christ or to the Soldiers. This is what the ropes are for. Although the apocryphal story of the mis-bored holes antedates the surviving plays, it proved extremely useful to the playwrights, since it explained not only why the Soldiers would be working with ropes in the immediate vicinity of Christ's body, but also why they would tie the ropes around Christ's hands.²³ Having established a dramatic reason for this much, an extension by which the ropes are tied around the Cross itself would be unlikely to confuse an audience, and would provide (along with the nails) solid grips for the actor playing Jesus to hang on to as the Cross is raised and dropped.²⁴

The two-stage raising of the Cross in York rings true both practically and dramatically. In order to provide a stage picture at all recognizable to those familiar with late medieval art and stained glass, the Cross needs to be between about thirteen and fifteen feet high: that is the height of the actor

plus about a foot above him for Pilate's inscription, a minimum of about three feet in the mortise for stability plus perhaps between three and five feet between the 'ground' and the footrest on which the actor stands. The cross-piece, which must extend beyond Christ's hands in both directions, must be around six feet wide (I checked just in case I ever have to play the part, and from finger-tip to finger-tip I am 5' 7" — which is also my height). The question of weight also rings true. In productions of many of these plays with the University of Toronto's *Poculi Ludique Societas* (now the Centre for Performance Studies in Early Theatre), we have always used hollow crosses, and we have found that raising a fourteen-foot cross with a 160lb body on it into a slot marginally larger than the cross is no mean feat, even with four basketball players as the soldiers. Neither the English plays nor the records gives us any idea whether the cross is hollow or solid, although the records of some continental plays such as those from Mons and Lucerne are explicit that a hollow cross should be used.²⁵ With a cross of solid wood the process of raising it would be significantly more difficult. Both the Soldiers' complaints — in York that he must put down his load before his back breaks, in Towneley that the load is beginning to wobble — will be encountered in rehearsal by any performance.

If this brief analysis of the surviving *Crucifixion* Plays from late medieval and early modern England has shown anything, it is how little information we can actually glean from most of them concerning the stage technology involved in the complex operation of raising the Cross. There should, I think, be no great surprise in this: in those few towns in which the Crucifixion was staged on a regular, perhaps annual, basis (such as Chester and York) the stage techniques would have been passed on year-by-year by those involved in the play's production, and there would be little need to write them down. We are, I think, very lucky that there was one playwright for whom these details formed an essential part of his narrative. The York playwright's attempts to reconcile the actions of his four Soldiers with their humanity led him to focus their concentration on the job and its tools. In this context, the Cross becomes one of the tools and the process of its elevation the major part of the job. The York Soldiers are far more interested in the successful completion of their job than in the person of Christ, and thus any interaction with him beyond that which is strictly required by Scripture has been converted into a verbalization of the action itself. It is precisely for this reason that the Soldiers give us what is essentially a blow-by-blow description of their raising of the Cross. I also suspect that it was the highly literary focus of the Towneley

playwright which led him away from this focus towards the poetic but not very dramatic topos of *Christus miles*.

Modern productions of the medieval *Crucifixion* plays have moved forward considerably in the half century since E. Martin Browne and Margaret Burkitt fudged the York and N.Town Crucifixions behind a wall of banners, and a substantial part of this movement has involved using what evidence there is in the plays to rediscover their staging techniques through performance. What we have been doing for the past forty years is, I think, the categorical opposite of the mode of thought which lies behind Mel Gibson's *Passion of the Christ*. Unlike Gibson's film, the plays of York and Chester, as well as the others less clearly localized, were not intended in any way to be recreations of an historical period. Costume evidence from iconographic sources, supported by the records, tells us that many of the costumes were contemporary; that is, with the exception of special effects like devils, and the 'biblical' costumes of the chief characters, many actors were costumed in the dress of their own period.²⁶ The fourth wall of much of our theatre for the past three hundred years was not a part of their dramaturgy and the audience itself was very much a participant in the action. As an invitation to *devotio moderna*, to the active participation in Christ's suffering, in the grief of his mother and disciples, in their fear of (or perhaps delight in) the devils, these plays offered their audiences a personal involvement in life and death of Christ which can never be found in the passive confines of a movie theatre.

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NOTES

1. John Elliott *Playing God* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1989) xx; Olga Horner 'The Law that Never Was: A Review of Theatrical Censorship in Britain' *Medieval English Theatre* 23 (2001) 34–96.
A photograph of Poel playing 'Adonai' is in the V & A Theatre Collection. It was on line at
< www.peopleplayuk.org.uk/collections/object.php?object_id=2040 >, but the site seems temporarily to have disappeared from the Web.
2. Stanley J. Kahrl *Traditions of Medieval English Drama* (London: Hutchinson, 1974) 92.
3. *Records of Early Drama: Wales* edited David N. Klausner (University of Toronto Press, 2005) 216. This document will be discussed in detail in my forthcoming article 'Playing the Crucifixion in Medieval Wales'.

4. Laurelle LeVert “‘Crucifye hem, Crucifye hem’: The Subject and Affective Response in Middle English Passion Narratives’ *Essays in Medieval Studies* 14 (1997) 73–87.
5. Kahr *Traditions* 92.
6. Georg Scheja *The Isenheim Altarpiece* (New York: Harry N. Abrams, 1969) 15–16. A good on-line image can be found at < www.wga.hu/support/viewer/z.html > .
7. *Nicholas Love’s Mirror of the Blessed Life of Jesus Christ* edited Michael G. Sargent (New York: Garland, 1992) 162.
8. The topos originated in the legend that the wood of the cross changed shape in an attempt to subvert the Crucifixion, but in the plays has been reinterpreted as a fault in the technology. See, for example, *Legends of the Holy Rood, Symbols of the Passion and cross Poems* edited Richard Morris *EETS* 46 (1871) 79–80.
9. Quotations from the York *Crucifixion* pageant are taken from *The York Plays* edited Richard Beadle (London: Edward Arnold, 1982) text 315–23.
10. Quotations from the N.Town *Passion Play* are taken from *The Passion Play from the N. Town Manuscript* edited Peter Meredith (London: Longman, 1990). Stage directions are indicated by ‘sd at’ and the immediately preceding line number.
11. *The Ancient Cornish Drama* edited Edwin Norris, 2 vols. (Oxford UP, 1859) 1 424.
12. Norris *Ancient Cornish Drama* 1 422.
13. Norris *Ancient Cornish Drama* 1 426.
14. Norris *Ancient Cornish Drama* 1 438–40, lines 2740–60.
15. ... *drehefough an grous yn ban / ha gyllefryeugh hy th’y le*; Norris *Ancient Cornish Drama* 1 444, lines 2812–13; my translation.
16. ... *how hale kettep onan / gesough hy a bart malan / yn morter skuat the gothe*; Norris *Ancient Cornish Drama* 1 444, lines 2814–16; my translation.
17. The manuscript diagram of the Ordinalia is vague on the disposition of the crosses (Norris *Ancient Cornish Drama* 1 219); clearer evidence of how they might be set up is provided by the drawings from the Lucerne Passion Play. See *The Staging of Religious Drama in Europe in the Later Middle Ages* edited Peter Meredith and John Tailby (Kalamazoo MI: Medieval Institute Publications, 1983) fold-out inside back cover.
18. *Three Welsh Religious Plays* edited Gwenan Jones (Bala: The Bala Press, 1939) 178: *Trewch vynieidie yr hoelon / yni draed ai ddwylo ddigon / kodwch yn ychel efo mal i gwelo yr iddewon*; my translation.
19. Peter Travis *Dramatic Design in the Chester Cycle* (University of Chicago Press, 1982), 185.
20. *The Chester Mystery Cycle* edited R.M. Lumiansky and David Mills *EETS* SS 3 (1974) text 303–24, at 313.

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21. On recent research concerning the provenance and date of the Towneley manuscript, see Barbara D. Palmer 'Recycling "The Wakefield Cycle": The Records' *Research Opportunities in Renaissance Drama* 41 (2002) 88–130.
22. *The Towneley Plays* edited A.C. Cawley and Martin Stevens *EETS SS 13 and 14* (1994) text 1 287–308; 2 290. See also Rosemary Woolf 'The Theme of Christ the Lover-Knight in Medieval English Literature' *Review of English Studies* NS 13 (1962) 1–16; reprinted in *Art and Doctrine: Essays on Medieval Literature* edited Heather O'Donoghue (London and Ronceverte: Hambledon Press, 1986) 99–117.
23. See note 8.
24. An interesting way of dealing with this problem was realised in the South African version of *The Mysteries — Yimimangaliso*, in which the Cross was made up of ladders.
25. *Staging of Religious Drama in Europe* edited Meredith and Tailby 124.
26. Meg Twycross discusses the distinction between 'theatrical' and 'contemporary' dress, especially in iconography: 'The Chester Cycle Wardrobe' in *Staging the Chester Cycle* edited David Mills (Leeds Texts and Monographs NS 9; Leeds: School of English, 1985) 100–23.